Restructuring the Bus Network Before the Congestion Trial

Executive Summary

The bus network restructure is fundable this year and the congestion pilot is not ready, so the sequencing question answers itself.

We recommend fixing the airport corridor contract first, then holding the charging trial until after the council elections.

Analysis

Operating margins for the city bus network contracted by 4.2 percent over the last three quarters because of rising driver wages and fuel costs, while ridership on the airport corridor grew by eleven percent after the express line opened.

The depot electrification pilot reduced maintenance outlays by nine percent, but charging downtime still erodes those savings during peak service hours.

Any restructuring of routes must therefore protect the airport corridor, which now generates a disproportionate share of network revenue.

Congestion charging remains politically fragile.

The trial zone cut weekday car entries by 17 percent, but two councillors face re-election next spring and will not endorse anything that smells like a commuter tax.

The park-and-ride expansion at Hallam Road was cheap and it worked; occupancy hit 85 percent within six weeks.

Recommendation

Fund the bus network restructure first, hold the congestion pilot until after the election cycle, and spend the remaining contingency on shelter upgrades along

the eastern routes, which scored highest in the accessibility audit.

Publish the corridor performance dashboard monthly so the panel can verify ridership claims without waiting for the annual report.

Case Prompt (identical for all candidates - do not modify): You are a strategy consultant engaged by the City Development Authority. Rising demand on public services and tightening municipal budgets have created pressure to identify fundable, high-impact interventions. Your task is to evaluate the feasibility of two shortlisted infrastructure initiatives, quantify expected costs and benefits over a five-year horizon, and recommend a phased implementation plan. Your submission must address financing options, stakeholder resistance, and delivery risks, and must include an executive summary, a structured analysis, and a clearly justified final recommendation supported by evidence. Word limit: 600 words. Citations are permitted where they support the analysis. Late submissions are scored as incomplete, and all claims must be verifiable from the provided case pack data.